



Not every pregnancy is as straightforward as it could be. Complications don't happen to most women—**they are not the norm**—but if you experience a problem you will get **lots of support** from your doctor. With careful attention, the majority of complications have **good outcomes**.

Complications

Types of complication

A “complication” is a medical condition that could potentially compromise your health or that of your unborn baby. Many of the checkups you are given as part of your prenatal care (and in your preconception care when you plan a pregnancy) are designed to identify any complications that could occur as early as possible. In many situations, your doctor can manage problems to keep you and your baby as safe as possible.

There are a few broad types of complication. Some women have a long-term condition, such as asthma or congenital heart disease, that warrants special attention. Sometimes previous gynecological issues may have an effect on your pregnancy. Other complications can arise as a result of pregnancy—gestational diabetes and preeclampsia are examples of these. More rarely, some short-term infections can pose problems.

Plan pregnancy where possible

If you are able, it is a good idea to check your immunity to certain infectious diseases before trying to get pregnant. You can be vaccinated before conception, but not while you are pregnant because some vaccines can harm a fetus.

If you have a preexisting illness that requires medication and you are not already pregnant, you are

strongly advised to put a preconception plan in place. Some medications aren't suitable for pregnancy, and some conditions need to be stabilized before you become pregnant. Giving yourself three to six months to get things planned and under control before conception can often mean the difference between a straightforward pregnancy and a difficult one.

When complications arise

If you experience a complication, your level of prenatal care might gear up with more tests, ultrasounds, and treatments. Throughout this process your doctor will explain what is going on in your body and its potential effects on your pregnancy, labor, birth, and baby.

Take someone with you to ultrasounds and appointments with specialists—they can listen if you are not able to take everything in. Sometimes you may need to make difficult decisions about whether or not to take medications that can help you, but potentially affect your baby. Sometimes, a complication might dictate where, when, and how you deliver your baby, forcing you to make unexpected decisions. It's natural to feel scared or nervous. There are support groups for people in the same situation as you—ask your doctor for information on these.